# Zenaida P. Hadji Raof Laidan

**Dr. Hadja Sittie Shayma Zenaida P. Hadji Raof Laidan** is a pioneering Maranao academician, science and technology advocate, and the first woman Regional Director of the Department of Science and Technology Regional Office XII (DOST XII) in the Philippines. Best known for championing Halal science development and establishing critical technology infrastructure across Mindanao, she's a bridge-builder who's connected government, academe, and private sector stakeholders to drive inclusive regional development. Her career has been defined by rigorous science, cultural rootedness, and a genuine passion for lifting up underserved communities, particularly in the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM) and Soccsksargen region.

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## Early Life and Family Background

Dr. Laidan hails from a distinguished Bangsamoro royal family. She's the daughter of Rajah Pangadapun Sumandar, Rajah Pangadapun sa Ganasi, heir to the thrones of Sultan sa Tugaya and Sultan sa Ramain, and a former mayor of Tugaya in Lanao del Sur. Her mother was Hadja Sittie Aishah Hadji Raof Sumandar, Baiya-Diamla (Muslim female regent) sa Tugaya. This noble lineage gave her both heritage and responsibility, though it was her own intellectual drive that ultimately shaped her remarkable journey.

The combination of royal lineage and her Maranao identity became central to her worldview. Growing up, she witnessed firsthand the challenges facing her community and the critical need for modern science and technology to address them. She carries the weight of that responsibility with dignity.

## Education and Academic Preparation

Dr. Laidan's educational path was marked by excellence and determination. She earned her Bachelor of Science in Inland Fisheries from Mindanao State University (MSU) in Marawi City, her hometown. Her academic talent earned her a prestigious National Science Development Board (NSDB, now DOST) scholarship, which supported her graduate studies.

In 1982, she completed her Master of Arts degree in Teaching General Science at her alma mater, MSU. Twelve years later, in 1994, she earned her Doctor of Philosophy degree in Science Education with a major in Biology from De la Salle University in Manila. Dr. Laidan was also conferred an Honorary Doctor of Philosophy degree in Institutional Development and Management from Sultan Kudarat State University and Akamai University in Hawaii in 2008, recognizing her professional contributions and leadership.

# Academic Career at Mindanao State University

Before her government appointment, Dr. Laidan spent twenty-two years as an Associate Professor (Level V) at the Mindanao State University-University Training Center (MSU-UTC), where she taught Chemistry, Biology, and General Science courses. Her colleagues knew her affectionately as "Zeny," and she earned a reputation as both a rigorous educator and someone genuinely invested in student development.

Beyond classroom instruction, Dr. Laidan took on leadership roles in professional organizations. She served as President of the Muslim Development Exponents Foundation of the Philippines, Inc., and as Board Director of the Muslim Educators League of the Philippines, Inc., both based in Marawi City. Through these roles, she pursued her passion for expanding educational access to Maranao women and underserved communities. In 1996, she founded the Science Learning Center in Marawi City to help preschoolers develop their full learning potential, reflecting her belief that education must start early and reach everyone.

# Government Service: DOST XII Regional Director

In 1991, Dr. Laidan was appointed Action Officer on Science and Technology in the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM), giving her her first opportunity to influence policy at scale.

Her appointment as Regional Director of DOST XII in 1999 marked a watershed moment not only for her career but for the region. She became the first woman to hold this position in the department's history. Since assuming office, she's distinguished herself through unwavering personal integrity and exemplary public service. As Regional Director, Dr. Laidan oversees the implementation of national science and technology agendas across Region XII and ARMM, with direct responsibility for fostering a competent, competitive, and socially conscious S&T community.

## Core Programs and Initiatives

Dr. Laidan's tenure has been defined by aggressive, results-oriented implementation of transformative programs:

- **Small Enterprise Technology Upgrading Program (SETUP):** Her office has helped thousands of small and medium enterprises (SMEs) across food processing, marine and aquaculture, horticulture, metals and engineering, woodcraft, and furniture sectors. Interventions include technology infusion, equipment provision, manpower training, technical assistance, product standardization, food safety protocols, and energy auditing.
- **Technology Institutional Support Program (TISP):** Rolling out emerging technologies to rural and remote areas, with special focus on ARMM and Region 12 communities.
- **Virtual Center in Technology Innovation in Information Technology (VCTI-IT):** Established to bridge academe and private sector, promoting globally competitive ICT-driven industries.
- **Tissue Culture and Clonal Nursery Development:** Advancing high-value fruit crops and ornamental plant production through modern biotechnology.

- **Regional Food Processing Centers:** She initiated establishment of a major food processing facility in Isulan, Sultan Kudarat, creating local employment and value-added opportunities.
- **Metrology Program:** Ensuring product standardization and competitiveness through rigorous testing and measurement protocols.
- **Philippines Science High School Campus, SOCCSKSARGEN Region:** Through her initiative and strong local networks, this prestigious science education facility was established in 2012 and immediately opened to scholars.
- **S&T Program for the Poor, Vulnerable and Disabled:** Reflecting her commitment to inclusive development.

All of these programs reflect a consistent philosophy: technology and science must serve the people, especially those without easy access to innovation.

### Institutional Leadership Roles

Dr. Laidan holds significant governance positions across Region XII's higher education landscape. She serves as Regent/Trustee of the Governing Board of University of Southern Mindanao (USM), Sultan Kudarat State University (SKSU), Cotabato City State Polytechnic College (CCSPC), Cotabato Foundation College of Science and Technology (CFCST), and Adiong Memorial Polytechnic State College (AMPSC). She's also a Trustee of the Environmental Protection and Conservation Center (ECPC) in Sarangani Province.

Additionally, Dr. Laidan chairs six major consortia coordinating science, technology, and development initiatives across South Central Mindanao: the Regional Information Technology and Electronic Commerce Committee (RITECC XII), Cotabato Region Industry and Energy Research and Development Consortium (CRIERDC), Region XII Analytical Laboratories Consortium (LABCON XII), Region XII Health Research and Development Consortium (HRDC XII), Region XII Nutrition and Communications Network (NUTRICOMNET XII), and the Halal S&T Consortium.

## Halal Science: A Global Leadership Agenda

If one achievement defines Dr. Laidan's career trajectory, it's her pioneering advocacy for Halal science and technology development. As a devout Muslim holding a senior position in the Philippines' premier S&T agency, she recognized a critical gap: the country lacked coherent scientific frameworks for Halal product development and certification, even as global Halal markets surged.

Dr. Laidan authored and now implements the **Philippine Science and Technology Program for the Development of the Halal Industry**, which became DOST's flagship Halal initiative. She chairs the National Halal Forum-Philippines, the country's leading Halal event, which evolved into the Philippine Halal Assembly and ultimately the World Halal Assembly Philippines, establishing the country as a credible voice in global Halal standardization.

More tangibly, she's the Founder and Administrator of the Halal Laboratory in Cotabato City, operational since 2010. In 2019, after a decade of her persistent advocacy and fundraising, the Philippine Halal Science Center and National Halal Laboratory opened in Koronadal City, commissioned as a clearing house for all Halal products entering and exiting the country. The facility provides comprehensive laboratory services for Halal standardization, testing, forensics analysis, and research and development, serving both MSMEs and multinational corporations.

This work earned her international recognition. The Standards and Metrology Institute for Islamic Countries (SMIIC) of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) granted DOST XII permission to adopt and implement its Unified Global Halal Standards, noting specifically SMIIC's confidence in Dr. Laidan's expertise and leadership.

## International Engagement and Speaking

Dr. Laidan's Halal Science expertise has made her a sought-after international speaker. She has presented at major global forums, including:

- World of Halal Science, Industry and Business (WHASIB) International Conference, Phuket, Thailand (June 2010)
- World Halal Forum 2008, Malaysia (May 2008)
- 2nd International Conference and Expo on Halal Industry, Lahore, Pakistan (January 2012)
- Saudi Food Forum, Jeddah, Kingdom of Saudi Arabia (December 2013)
- Japan Halal Summit 2014, Tokyo (August 2014)
- Halal Korea Expo 2015, Seoul (August 2015)
- World Halal Summit Istanbul 2016, Turkey
- World Halal Convention East Europe 2017, Poznan, Poland (September 2017)
- World Halal Summit 2017, Istanbul, Turkey (November 2017)
- Halal International Conference 2017, Bangkok, Thailand (November 2017)
- Iran Halal Conference 2017, Mashhad, Iran (December 2017)
- World Halal Assembly Oman 2018 (May 2018)
- Thailand Halal Assembly 2018 (December 2018)

She has also led benchmarking missions, including a significant study mission to Malaysia in 2014 to explore best practices in Halal industry strengthening. In 2015, she organized the Philippine Halal Assembly International Conference and Expo at the Marriott Manila, where SMIIC formally granted DOST XII its global standards authorization.

## Recognition and Royal Honors

Dr. Laidan's contributions have been recognized through numerous awards. During Kamindanawan 2011, she was honored as one of the Outstanding Top Women Mindanao Achievers for "breaking new ground" through science, technology, and innovation, particularly for championing Halal science in the Philippines.

On May 15, 2014, Dr. Laidan was conferred a distinguished royal honor, being crowned and enthroned as **Bai-a-Zeybaaleem sa Masiu**, a noble Bangsamoro women's title with the equivalent rank of Sultan in the Royal Sultanate of Lanao. This recognition honored both her professional accomplishments and her embodiment of Maranao cultural values and leadership.

## Publications and Research

Dr. Laidan is a licensed fishery biologist and prolific researcher. Her academic work has been published in peer-reviewed international journals and presented at science and technology conferences. Notable publications include:

- "Status of Bachelor of Science for Secondary Programs Major in Biology Offered by Selected Institutions in the National Capital Region," published in *Asia Life Sciences* (International Journal of Life Sciences), Volume 4, No. 2 (July-December 1995)
- "Some Effects of Water Hyacinths (Eichhornia crassipes, Linn.) on Some Physico-Chemical Parameters of Lake Lanao," published in *BIOTA Journal* (February 1996)

## Dimensions of Her Impact

What makes Dr. Laidan's leadership distinctive is her holistic approach to development. Early in her career, she focused on particular sectoral needs; as DOST XII Regional Director, her vision expanded to address interconnected challenges across food security, economic competitiveness, environmental sustainability, education, and cultural preservation. She's simultaneously a scientist, educator, administrator, cultural ambassador, and bridge-builder among disparate stakeholders.

Her work has generated measurable outcomes: thousands of SMEs upgraded with new technologies; numerous food and fruit processing centers established; the loom-weaving industry in ARMM and Cotabato City revitalized; a premier science high school opened to talented but under-resourced scholars; and a world-class Halal science infrastructure built to serve both the Philippines and the global Muslim business community.

Perhaps most importantly, Dr. Laidan has demonstrated that Bangsamoro leadership in science, technology, and development is not aspirational, it's achievable, and it can be done with both rigor and cultural integrity.

## Further Reading


- Profile of Dr. Hadja Sittie Shayma Zenaida P. Hadji Raof Laidan. BangsamoroPedia, March 26, 2019.
- Department of Science and Technology Regional Office XII (DOST XII) Official Publications and Program Directories.
- Philippine Halal Science Center and National Halal Laboratory Official Records.


## See Also

- Bangsamoro
- Maranao
- Mindanao State University
- Department of Science and Technology (Philippines)
- Halal
- Science and technology in the Philippines
- Women in Science and Technology (Philippines)
- Tugaya, Lanao del Sur


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